

Needed: Jan AI

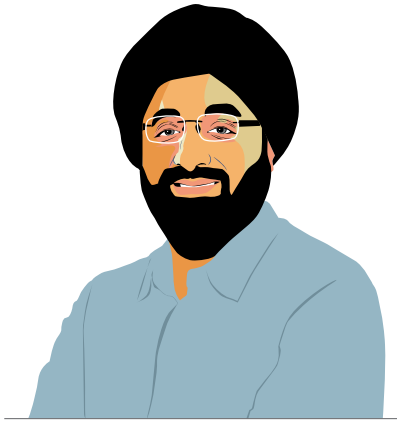
India must build its own LLMs and apps as part of the fabled 'India Stack' like it did with UPI and Aadhaar



NE MIGHT THINK that the spark that ignited this revolution was ChatGPT in November 2022, but OpenAI's runaway hit just provided the final kindling to a slow fire that was burning since 1955 when AI (artificial intelligence) was envisaged first in the now famous Dartmouth Conference. The pace of innovation in the last two years since ChatGPT is unmatched—with many powerful LLMs (Large Language Models) from Big Tech firms and start-ups beating humans in some faculties, a Cambrian Explosion of applications running on top of these foundation models bringing AI to workplaces and businesses, and recently the Chinese model DeepSeek upending the costs and resources narrative and promising to democratise AI.

154 |

The Age of AI is well upon us, and the question is what India should do to leverage it towards its goals of a developed and equitable economy by 2047. India is well positioned to capitalise on this AI boom given its army of software developers and engineers, a thriving start-up ecosystem, global IT companies, a huge domestic market, its population-scale Digital Public Infrastructure, and a proactive government with an innovation agenda. It consistently ranks among the Top 5 AI countries in most global rankings, and receives a throng of AI grandees like Sam Altman, Jensen Huang, Yann LeCun ever so often, adding heft to its



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AI ambitions. Having said that, the two clear AI super powers who tower above every other country are the US and China, with most of the innovation, infrastructure, capital and research centred around them. In this scenario, while India would continue to build on the basics, it would need some out-of-the-box thinking and execution to leapfrog to become another AI leader.

The comforting fact is that India has done this before.

Even before we leapfrog, India will need to execute on the basics, and to be a global leader, that means investing and building across the AI stack, from GPUs to applications to research. This implies building AI infra in the country, thus building our own AI chips and data centres. While creating TSMC-level fabs is extremely expensive and difficult, building AI does not require only the latest 1.2nm chips and DeepSeek R1 has shown how it is possible to build foundation models on older GPUs and lesser of them. India will need to build a level of self-reliance, or *atmanirbharta*, on the basic infrastructure of AI. We will also need to build our own LLM, and the economics and possibilities of doing this have opened up greatly in the last two years, especially with plummeting infrastructure costs and clever algorithmic and systems tweaks, demonstrated again by DeepSeek, making it easier to build foundation models. It is heartening that now MeitY (Ministry of Electronics and Information